



CHILE

Capital city: Santiago
Area: 292,258 sq miles (756,950 sq km)
Population: 15,800,000
Official language: Spanish
Major religions: Christian 80%, other 20%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Chilean peso
Adult literacy rate: 96%
Life expectancy: 76 years
People per doctor: 909
Televisions: 232 per 1,000 people

CHILE

A NATIVE OF CHILE ONCE SAID that his country had a crazy geography. It is the longest, thinnest country in the world. Protected by the Andes, it was the last country in the Americas to be occupied by the Spanish, but gained its independence in 1818. Since the end of a cruel military dictatorship that lasted from 1973–1990, the country has enjoyed a stable political life. Most people live in central Chile around the capital, Santiago, and the main port of Valparaíso. Fruit, cereals, and grapes are cultivated in the valleys, which are well watered by rivers from the Andes. Fishing off the long Pacific coast is also important.



CHILEAN WINE

Vines were first brought to Chile by the Spanish, who grew grapes for their communion wine. Today, the valleys that surround Santiago contain some of the best vineyards on the American continent. Chilean red and white wines are exported around the world.



COPPER MINING

Chile is the world's largest exporter of copper, and also mines significant quantities of iron ore, coal, gold, silver, and other minerals. High up in the Atacama Desert, in the north of Chile, lies one of the world's largest deposits of copper. The mine at Chuquibambata is 13,500 ft (4,115 m) long and 2,200 ft (670 m) deep. Every week millions of tons of rock are blasted out of the ground and processed to produce copper.

CHANGING SCENERY

From the dry, barren lands of the Atacama Desert in the north to the icy rocks of Cape Horn in the south, Chile includes almost every type of climate and landscape in the world. The northern desert is one of the driest places on Earth, while the central agricultural valley has a Mediterranean climate similar to California or southern Europe. In the cold and stormy south, 55 volcanoes are currently active, and huge glaciers block the valleys. More than 80 percent of the country is mountainous, and much of the rest is forested. Not much land is available for growing crops.

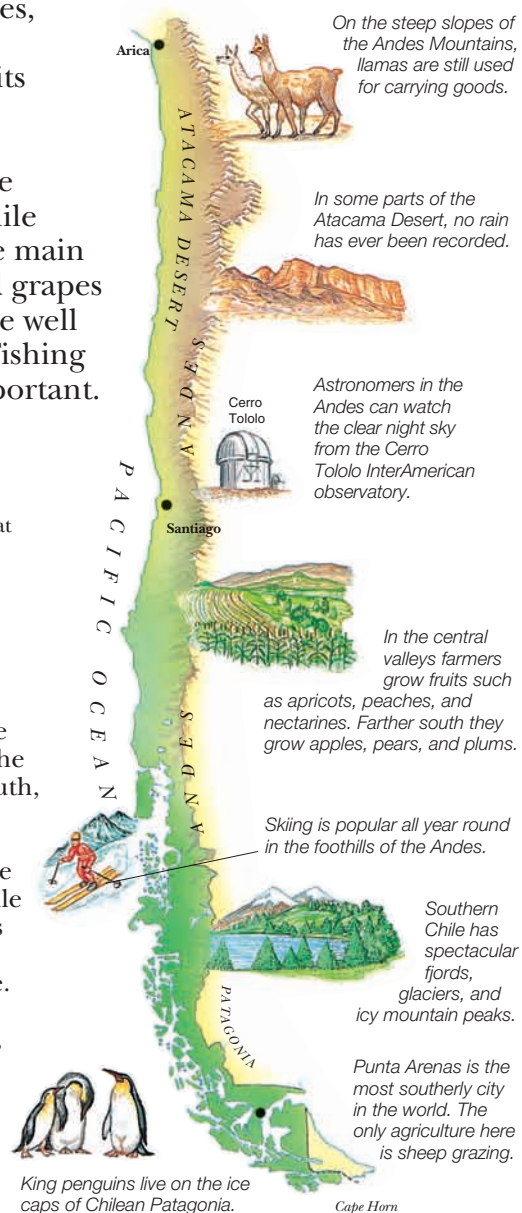
MAPUCHE INDIANS

For centuries, the Mapuche Indians have fought for their independence, first against the Incas of Peru, then against invading Spaniards, and most recently against the Chilean government. Today, most of the 600,000 Mapuche live on reservations in the south. One of Chile's main soccer teams, Colo-Colo, is named after an old Mapuche chief.



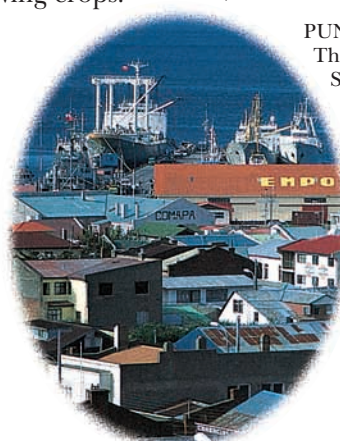
From north to south

Chile is 2,610 miles (4,200 km) long from north to south – the same as the distance from Norway to Nigeria. At no point is the country more than 112 miles (180 km) wide.



PUNTA ARENAS

The city of Punta Arenas lies on the Straits of Magellan, the route used by ships to avoid stormy Cape Horn. The port is filled with fishing and Antarctic research vessels and is a base for oil exploration. It lies under the hole in the ozone layer above Antarctica, and people are easily burned by the Sun's rays.



Find out more

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